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THE PATHWAY TOWARDS LIFE OF DIGNITY

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The case story book has been developed with the collective efforts, commitment, and cooperation of many individuals. This publication reflects not only documented outcomes, but also the shared commitment to ensuring that working children are protected from hazardous labour and supported to live with dignity, hope, and opportunity.

My heartfelt gratitude goes to the children, young people, and their families whose real-life journeys are at the heart of this booklet. Their courage, resilience, and determination to move away from hazardous work and pursue safer, more dignified lives are truly inspiring. I also acknowledge the valuable contributions of community members and local stakeholders who stood beside these children and supported positive change at the grassroots level.

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Finally, I gratefully acknowledge our donors and partners for their trust, collaboration, and continued support. It is our sincere hope that this case story booklet will serve as a learning resource, inspire stakeholders, and strengthen collective efforts toward eliminating hazardous child labour and ensuring a dignified future for every child.

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PROJECT OVERVIEW

"**Options for Dignity of Human Beings by Influencing Key Actors to Reform (ODHIKAR), Phase II**" project is a continuation of Educo's long-standing commitment to eliminating hazardous child labour in urban Bangladesh. The project focuses on children engaged in high-risk sectors, including domestic work, transport services, automobile workshops, and scavenging. Implementation is concentrated in the Shyamoly Housing area under Adabor Thana of Dhaka City Corporation.

The project is implemented in partnership with the Eco-Social Development Organization (ESDO), the local NGO partner from ODHIKAR Phase I, with funding support from ChorogUsan for children and Educo Bangladesh. In addition to enrolling newly identified working children, the project provides follow-up and mainstream education support to children from Phase I, ensuring the sustainability of earlier achievements from the three communities of Adabor and Mohammadpur Thana.

The overall goal of the project is to improve access to education and significantly reduce hazardous child labour in Dhaka City, particularly in domestic work, transport services, automobile workshops, and scavenging.

The project contributes to three key outcomes. First, child labour-related laws, policies, and regulations are strengthened, adopted, and practiced at the national level. Second, children engaged in hazardous labour are withdrawn and supported through education, child protection, and reintegration services. Third, communities are empowered to actively prevent and combat child labour and exploitation through strengthened local mechanisms and increased awareness.

ODHIKAR–Phase II is implemented from August 2022 to December 2025. The project directly benefits 390 working children and 780 parents. Indirectly, approximately 100,000 individuals, including community members, employers, and local stakeholders, benefit from the project's interventions.

The project is implemented by Eco-Social Development Organization (ESDO) in partnership with Educo Bangladesh, with strategic collaboration from BSAF, BILS, Shapla Neer, and ASD. The project is closely engaged with the Child Labour Elimination Platform (CLEP), where Educo Bangladesh is working as the Secretariat of the platform.

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A CHILDHOOD THAT NO CHILD SHOULD LIVE

JISAN'S FIGHT BETWEEN LEARNING AND LABOUR

Every morning, **Jisan** puts on his school uniform with pride only to trade it for work clothes just hours later. At just 13, his childhood is split between the classroom and the struggle to survive, where he risks physical injuries collecting scrap and working in night shifts. This is the kind of childhood no child deserves.

Jisan's family is burdened with heavy debt. His father drove an auto-rickshaw and his mother joined a garment factory. Despite both parents working tirelessly, the family faced crushing financial pressure, having to repay 13, 000 taka each month to lenders in their village and an additional BDT 8,000 installment for the rickshaw loan. The earnings barely meet the ends, let alone education fees. Jisan once was admitted to a Madrasah but the burden was too heavy and he was forced to drop out.

When Jisan's younger brother was born, his mother fell seriously ill and had to stop working temporarily, leaving his father as the sole breadwinner of the family. So, at a young age, Jisan had to step in and he had to cover the expenses with three jobs.

At first, he works as a helper on a leguna (a local transport vehicle) until midday, earning between 50 to 100 taka. He then spend the rest of the day collecting scrap, which brings in another 100 to 200 taka. His efforts do not stop there, at night, he works at an embroidery shop from 9:00 PM to 7:00 AM, earning 3,000 taka per month. Juggling three jobs, Jisan earns a total of around 5,000 to 6,000 taka a month, all of which he gives to his parents for room rent and other costs.

The conditions he faced each day were not just difficult, they were dangerous. The fear of a serious accident was constant. Collecting scrap was not just exhausting, it was painful. With only three hours before heading straight to his night shift at the embroidery shop. There, he stands for hours through the night, changing needles and working with sharp objects, constantly exposed to the risk of cutting his hands. Additionally, most of the time he leaves home early in the morning with an empty stomach and little to no sleep.

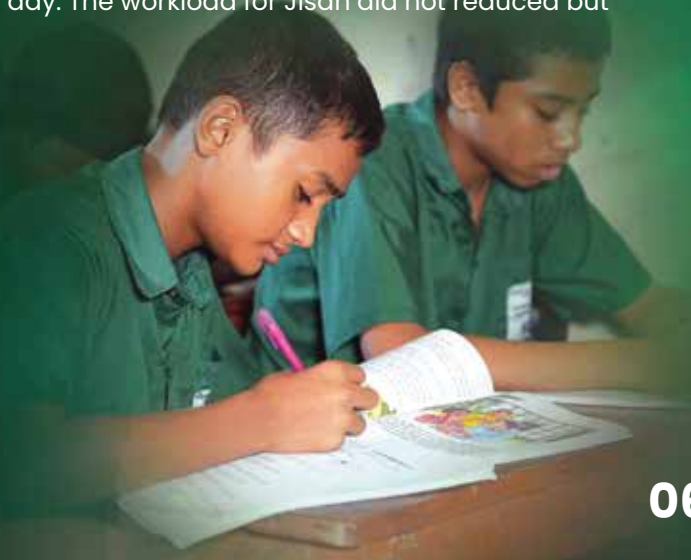
He shared, **"Of all the work I do, the most painful is the embroidery job, where I have to work long hours while struggling to stay awake. If I get drowsy, even for a moment, I have to endure the**

inhumane behaviour and harsh insults from my employer." Not only that, but the constant noise in the embroidery shop often gives Jisan chronic headaches.

The harsh realities of child labour took a toll on Jisan's mental and social development. Juggling multiple jobs left him emotionally drained and vulnerable. He shared, "Whenever I saw my neighbours going to school, I used to feel very sad, but then I thought if I do not help my parents, we will not have anything to eat." This reflects his sense of responsibility which is a way ahead of his age.

One day, a friend introduced Jisan to ODHIKAR Pathshala, an initiative supported by Educo Bangladesh and co-implemented ESDO, funded by ChorogUsan for children. Though he could not attend regularly due to work but every moment spent there gave him hope. He found joy in learning and a sense of belonging among classmates. His desire to study grew stronger and with persistent requests, he convinced his father to let him enroll in school.

Today, he is in Grade 5 and attends school every day. The workload for Jisan did not reduced but still he managed his time for the school. After class, he still works to help his family repay debts and cover basic expenses.



At school, he not only receives an education but also a nutritious, filling lunch and life skills sessions. These sessions have helped him regain his confidence and manage his emotions, allowing him to grow as a social being. He enjoys playing carrom board and cricket, which he often does in his free time. However, he has to sacrifice an hour of sleep just to play cricket. He is still struggling, but now he has friends with whom he feels heard, supported, and valued.

Despite Jisan's exhausting routines, the time he spends in school has brought light into his life. He enjoys drawing, playing with friends, using the computer and being in an enabling environment.

Jisan dreams of becoming a building engineer, an architect, in his words. He shared, "When I grow up, I want to become an engineer of buildings." He added, "Too many people live in Dhaka, and these tall buildings collapse and people die because of corruption in construction. I want to build strong buildings so no more lives are lost."

FROM CHILD LABOURER TO ASPIRING TEACHER

THE STORY OF HAFSA AKTER

Hafsa Akter, 15, was born into a family grappling with chronic debt. Her childhood was not one of play but of responsibility. Yet her story is a powerful testament to how targeted intervention, community engagement and access to education can break the cycle of poverty and ignite a passion for change.

For escaping from poverty, her family moved to the capital only to find a different kind of struggle. From the age of 7, she was sent to work as a domestic helper to contribute to the family income. Her father's recurring illness and the growing family plunged them deeper into financial crisis.

Hafsa, still a child herself, began working in multiple households, earning a meager 4,000 taka per month, all of which she handed over to her father. The work was exhausting, the scolding was constant and the possibility of education seems like a distant dream.

In a home, a defining moment of cruelty ignited a fire within her. When she picked up a book belonging to her employer, she snatched it away, shouting, "You're just a maid. Why are you touching the book?" Tearfully, Hafsa asked her mother, **"Are maids never allowed to study? Were we born only to clean other people's houses?"**

Moved by their daughter's plea, Hafsa's parents began searching for a school. A neighbour told them about the ODHIKAR Pathshala. The project model was a perfect fit for the situations like Hafsa, since it was free of cost with the flexibility to continue working part-time. In 2022, at the age of 12, Hafsa was enrolled in Class 3.

She recognises the role of Educo and ESDO in her transformation, she said, **"I'm thankful to them because their support gave me the courage to dream. If they keep supporting me, I believe I can reach my goals and build a better life."**

Hafsa's journey from a child labourer to an aspiring educator highlights the critical importance of accessible education for the most vulnerable.

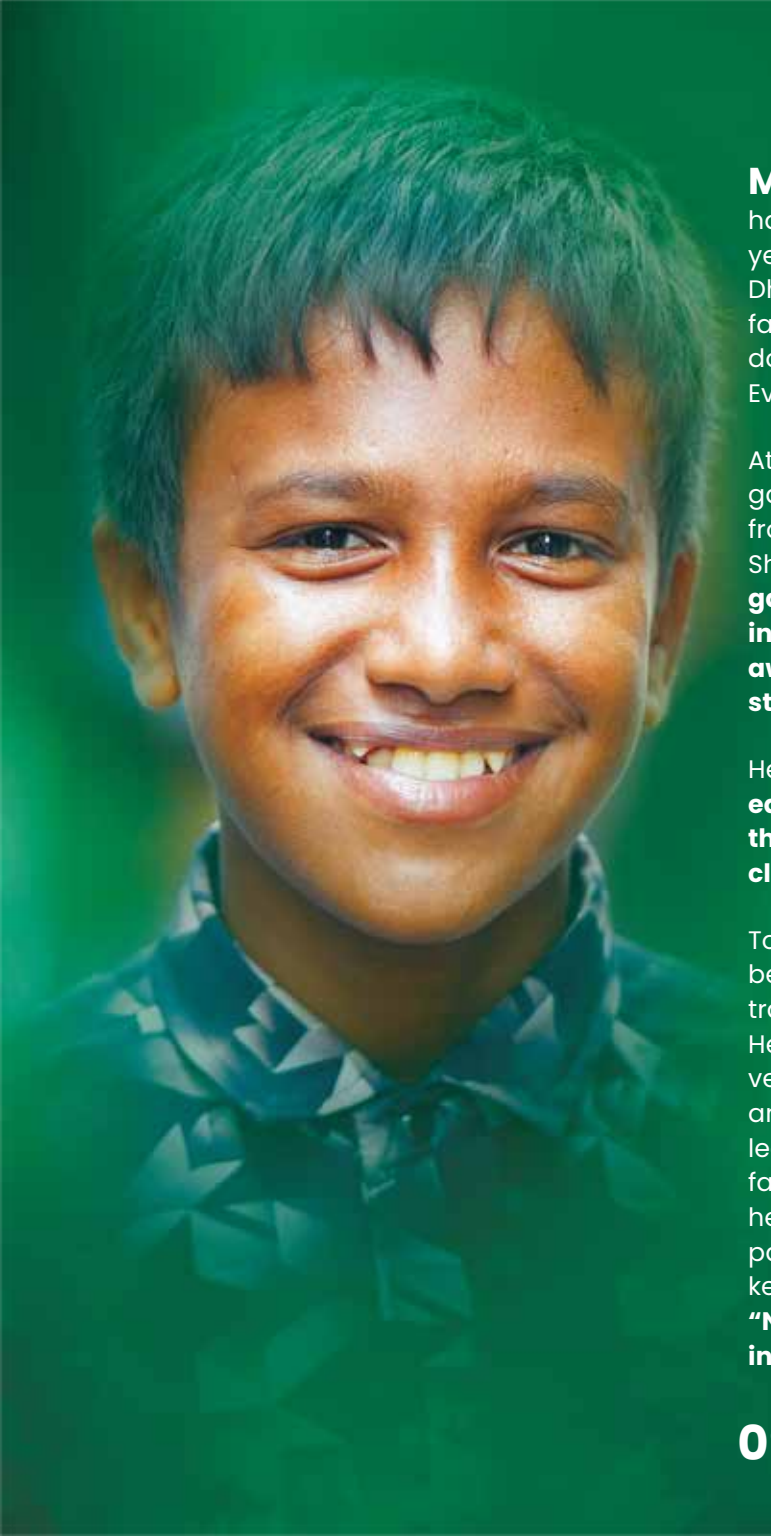
She quickly proved to be a bright, attentive, and hardworking student. However, the old life never left her side, with a huge medical debt, her father began pressuring her to quit school and work full-time once more. Hafsa shared her struggles with her teachers, who, along with community members, counseled her father on the long-term value of education.

A pivotal opportunity arose when Hafsa was offered a chance to tutor younger students. This initiative transformed her life. She transitioned to an aspiring teacher. Now she earns around BDT 5,000 a month which is more dignified and sustainable income that still supported her family.

Today, Hafsa is no longer the silent maid forbidden from touching books. She is a determined student with a clear vision. She said, **"I want aware parents and people who don't always understand the value of education, to help them give their children a better future."**

WHEN SCHOOL BECOMES A LIFELINE

SHAGOR MOLLAH'S JOURNEY FROM GARBAGE FIELD TO PLAYGROUND



Md. Shagor Mollah, 14, is a child whose life has been shaped by abandonment, poverty and pain, yet somehow, he still dreams. Born in the slum area in Dhaka, Shagor was only three months old when his father left the family. His mother began working as a domestic worker but she could not continue for long. Eventually, she was forced to beg to survive.

At the age of 8, Shagor stepped in to help, collecting garbage on the streets to earn a few coins each day from 50-80 taka, just enough to buy a little rice. Shagor said, **"Sometimes, I do not want to work as a garbage collector because of the smell and I often injure myself with the sharp objects people throw away. One time, I cut my leg so bad it needed two stiches and I had to stay in bed for a whole week."**

He added, **"But I have no choice, I have to work to earn some extra money. What hurts me the most is that we do not even have soap at home. I neither clean myself properly nor wash my only shirt."**

To survive, Shagor continued collecting garbage and began working as a helper on a leguna, a local transport vehicle, dangerous work for a boy his age. He was frequently injured, falling from the moving vehicle, often with no help from his employer or anyone around. He shared "My employer starts the leguna before I even adjust myself in it, so I used to fall frequently. Instead of giving me medicine or helping me, my employer insulted me in front of the passengers and no one ever stood up for me." Still, he kept going because he had no other choice. He said, **"Now I do not feel anything, whether I fall, get insulted or beaten. I have gotten used to it."**

In the middle of this daily struggle, Shagor always wished for something for a school, a classroom, a space where he could just be a child. That wish came true in 2023, when he was admitted to ODHIKAR Pathshala funded by ChorogUsan for children. He enrolled in class 2 and found a world he had only dreamed of, where he could study, play and eat a warm, nutritious meal. He told us, **"Often the food I get in the tiffin is the only food I eat in a day".**

Now, every morning, Shagor walks into school, leaving behind the burdens of adulthood for a few hours. His teachers say he is quick, curious and brave. Shagor's life has not changed drastically but he finds comfort in the fact that he is finally able to study. With the psychosocial support provided at school, he has learned to manage his emotions better. He is beginning to discover his own potential and natural leadership abilities. ODHIKAR Pathshala is not only helping Shagor continue his education it is also making him aware of his rights and the value he holds as a child.

What keeps him going is a fragile but powerful dream. One day, he wants to become a good driver, who earns enough to care for his mother, and help other fatherless **children like him live a better life. "I want to do something so that kids like me do not have to suffer this way,"** he said.

Shagor's story is not just about poverty or pain, it is about strength that refuses to give up and a dream that refuses to die.

RISING BEYOND HARDSHIP WITH DETERMINATION AND HOPE

Annie Akter, 18, now an eleventh-grade Diploma in Engineering student, has lived a life shaped by instability, hardship and relentless resilience. Her parents, cast out by relatives due to their financial constraints, later, they migrated to Dhaka in search of survival. Her father a rickshaw puller while her mother worked as a domestic helper.

Annie began her education at a local school but her journey was interrupted when she fell on the roadside and fractured her left hand. The injury still aches today. On the other hand, her mother's health deteriorated and the family's financial struggles intensified. So, at only the age of 11, Annie was sent to work as a domestic helper.

Working in other people's house was unbearable for her. She recalled, "Once, I burned my hand while lifting a pot from the stove, they offer no help. Additionally, they often slapped me if I worked too slowly." At home, there was no peace as well, she often lived in emotional distress due to the frequent quarrels between her parents.

A turning point came when her mother heard about ODHIKAR Pathshala, where children could study while working. Annie was enrolled in class 3, enabling her to return to learning. Her father, however, continued to oppose her education, and after the COVID-19 shutdown, he refused to allow her to enrol her in class 6. Her aunt stepped in, paying her expenses until class 8, but when her aunt's business collapsed, her education stood on the edge once more.

Then, teachers from ODHIKAR Pathshala intervened, assessing her situation and taking responsibility for her schooling. And in 2025, Annie passed her SSC examination with a perfect GPA of 5.00, an extraordinary achievement given the barriers she faced.

She expressed, **"My dream of being educated came true because of the teachers who spoke to my parents and supported my dream."** ODHIKAR project did not only took responsibility for her education but made her aware about her rights as a human.

Today, with the renewed confidence and a growing sense of possibility, she dreams of becoming a graphic designer and one day building her own business. Her journey stands as an example not only to her courage, but also to the power of education to transform a child's future.

RAJON'S JOURNEY FROM GARBAGE TRUCK TO CLASSROOM

At just **14, Md. Rajon Mia**, dreams of soaring above Dhaka's crowded streets as a pilot, bringing home stranded Bangladeshis who cannot afford to return. His voice carries hope, but his childhood has been shaped by hardship that no child should ever endure.

Before he found ODHIKAR Pathshala, Rajon believed he carried no dignity, no identity and no future, but education changed everything. Rajon's family spiraled into crisis began when his father's gambling addiction created heavy debts and forced them to flee the village. In Dhaka, his father laboured irregularly, and his mother cleaned houses to support their four children. After a severe head injury left his father unable to work, medical costs consumed what little they had, plunging the family deeper into debt.

With no alternatives, Rajon and his younger brother were pushed into hazardous child labour. From morning to evening, they worked on garbage trucks for only 150 taka a day. Rajon worked barefoot to avoid slipping, leaving his feet and legs constantly cut and infected. "One day I fell while carrying a heavy rubbish container," he recalled. **"I lost consciousness, and there was blood everywhere."** Unable to afford a doctor, he wrapped his wounds with scraps of cloth and returned to work a week later.

But the physical danger was only part of the pain. Rajon faced daily insults from his employer and harsh beatings at home whenever he earned too little. Social rejection cut even deeper. "No one wanted to come near me or play with me because

of the smell," he said quietly. "It made me feel less than human."

Rajon often cried when he saw other children going to school. He longed for a classroom but believed it was impossible. A neighbour finally told his father about ODHIKAR Pathshala, a school where children could study while working part-time. In 2023, Rajon restarted his education in class 1. Now he is in class 5, he attends school every afternoon after working a safer job collecting group scrap in the mornings. "When I started school, I quit working on the garbage truck," he said with a smile.

ODHIKAR Pathshala offers more than lessons. Children receive nutritious meals, life-skills training and computer classes. Rajon's confidence slowly returned as he learned to manage his emotions, make decisions and imagine a future for himself. He now has friends, feels valued and is proud of his identity.

He said, **"Thanks to Educo Bangladesh, ESDO and ChorogUsan for children, we have a safe space to study and play. Now I believe I can fulfil my father's dream."** Rajon now dreams of becoming a pilot not for prestige, but to bring stranded Bangladeshis back home. A boy once pushed to society's margins now imagines a future where he lifts others too.

A CHILDHOOD CARRIED BY HOPE AND LIFTED BY ODHIKAR PATHSHALA

For most of his childhood, Md. Maruf lived between anxiety and responsibility, two things no child should carry. **Maruf, 15**, grew up witnessing his parents' daily struggle to repay debt, afford medicine and simply keep the family afloat. His father worked as a truck helper, his mother as a housemaid, and even their combined earnings were rarely enough.

Everything changed when Maruf was 7. His father's severe spinal injury left him unable to work and pushed the family further into further crisis. His mother took out daily loans just to buy medicine. With no other option, young Maruf had to become adult far too soon, working 12 hours a day as a helper on a leguna. His small hands carried passengers' bags, his feet slipped on sharp metal bars, and his earnings, only about BDT 200 a day, went straight to buying his father's pills.

He still remembers the night he came home bleeding after falling off the vehicle. He said, **"I couldn't sleep from the pain. But the next morning, I went to work again. If I didn't, my father wouldn't get his medicine."** He often watched other children going to school and wondered if learning was something meant only for children with easier lives.

Through it all, his mother held on to one dream, “No matter how hard life gets, I’ll make sure my child study. One day, he will become a government officer.” However, dreams are difficult to sustain when there is no money for school fees, notebooks or even a proper uniform. After class 1, Maruf had to drop out, humiliated by the condition of his clothes and the weight of poverty.

Things shifted in 2018, when ODHIKAR Pathshala opened its doors to him. Enrolled in class 2, Maruf found not just a classroom but a lifeline. The teachers listened, encouraged and ensured he continued his studies without financial burden. For the first time, Maruf could imagine a future that wasn’t shaped by struggle.

Even during the COVID-19 closures, ODHIKAR ensured he transferred to mainstream school so he wouldn’t lose his pace. Later, Educo Bangladesh with the help of ChorogUsan for children, supported him from class 9, keeping his education uninterrupted.

But ODHIKAR’s impact didn’t end with Maruf. At the end of 2023, the project reached out again, this time ensuring the entire family could stand on stronger footing. Through the project, his mother received sewing training, a sewing machine and seed capital. This marked the beginning of her small tailoring and fabric business. His father recovered enough to drive a CNG. For the first time in years, stability returned to their home.

Today, Maruf completely withdraw from child labour and focused on studies. He is in class 9 at a good school. He dreams of become a magistrate, to stand against injustice, fight corruption and build a better Bangladesh. He is now a young man preparing to lead, to serve and to rewrite the future that once seemed out of reach.

RIMA RECLAIMING HER FUTURE THROUGH EDUCATION AND COURAGE

Rima's story begins in a small village in Bhola, where she was burdened by economic hardship and early marriage. Yet her resilience and unwavering determination have made her an inspiration among her peers. Now, she is a 21-year-old aspiring young woman with a dream of becoming a writer.

Rima's family used to live with the extended family members under one roof. Her father worked as a day labourer in construction sites, but the income was irregular. Yet the greatest hardship in her life came not from poverty, but from internalised misogyny at home. As the first daughter, Rima and her mother were subjected to constant verbal and physical abuse from her grandmother, who believed that girls were a burden. After a while, Rima and her parents moved to Dhaka for better opportunities.

Life in the capital was difficult, but it was also the first place where Rima found a small sense of belonging. Her mother enrolled her in ODHIKAR Pathshala near their residence, and she discovered joy in learning. But when her mother fell ill, the family's financial pressures intensified. So, at just age 10, Rima was sent to work as a domestic helper.

Even at that age, she always dreams of learning. She used to tell her mother, **"I don't want to work. Please buy me books and a school bag."** But in a family of limited resources survival will always take priority. Around that time, ODHIKAR Pathshala reopened nearby, and its teachers began visiting households in the community. When they met Rima, they encouraged her to return to school, a turning point that changed the direction of her life.

With ODHIKAR's flexible schedule, Rima worked half the day and attended school from 2:00 to 5:00 p.m. In school, she played, learned, drew pictures, recited poems, and began writing short stories with the encouragement of her teachers. She dreamed of becoming a writer. But when the COVID-19 pandemic struck, schools closed and her father sent the children back to the village. Her grandmother pushed her for early marriage, and before she could complete class 8, she was married off against her will.

Married life brought new barriers. Yet hope and her determination found a way. Rima revisited the school. The teachers, who had once guided her, helped her enroll in class 9 to resume her interrupted education.

Today, Rima studies while managing her household and caring for her unwell mother-in-law. Her journey is far from easy, but she continues with quiet determination driven by the belief that education still holds the power to change her future.

A DREAM FORGED IN ADVERSITY

THE STORY OF MONIR HOSSAIN

Imagine having a passion for studying but forced to work in a sawdust-filled environment of a furniture shop where anyone can hardly breathe. There works a young man, eyes full of dreams and heart full of steady moves for on a bright future. His name is **Monir Hossain, an 18-year-old youth**, who has just completed his dream of passing SSC examination against all the adversities of life.

Born into a financially limited family of eight, he is the fourth child. From the beginning, poverty was the unyielding backdrop of his childhood and tragedy is a frequent visitor. Monir's father is a rickshaw puller, his mother a domestic helper and his older brother a cleaner in a small restaurant. Despite the collective effort, the family could barely afford regular meals.

Monir managed to study up to class 2 with his mother's help but his father never supported his children's education, and sent him to work as a laguna helper. Monir was pushed into the world of child labour. He used to earn BDT 150 each day and forced to hand over the entire amount to his father. Monir recalled one of his experiences and shared, **"One day, a passenger paid less than the full fare, when I asked for the correct amount, he slapped me hard, and my boss didn't say a word. That day I realised how cruel life can be."**

In 2018, an opportunity arrived at Monir's door steps. He was enrolled in class 3 at ODHIKAR Pathshala, an initiative for working children like him. Initially, his work schedule prevented regular attendance. However, the persistent advocacy of his teachers and the CLCLMC members with his employer and parents secured a critical compromise which allows Monir to balance work and school.

The subsequent years were a rollercoaster of academic progress and domestic turmoil. Monir moved to another school and he shared, “Watching parents fight every day made me lose interest in studying. Sometimes I’d run away and stay at friends’ houses for days. My father accused my mother and me of stealing money for my education and often beat us. Once, he even called the police on us.”

When it seemed, the pressure would force him to drop out, a lifeline appeared. In 2023, while Monir was in class 9, Educo Bangladesh identified him and took full responsibility for his education. “If they hadn’t supported me, I would’ve dropped out and ended up as a child labourer again,” Monir states emphatically.

This consistent support proved transformative. Monir studied vocational subjects and passed his Secondary School Certificate (SSC) examination with an impressive GPA of 4.32, a monumental achievement given his circumstances.

Today, Monir is a college student, studying in class 11 at Graphics Arts College. He continues to work part-time with his father at the furniture shop but now his labour supports his future, rather than imprisoning him in the present.

He dreams to empower others and become a changemaker. He said, **“Now, I dream to become a successful entrepreneur so that I can create jobs for children like me, where they can work for half day and go to school on the other half.”**

Monir’s story is a powerful testament to the fact that with persistent support the cycle of poverty and child labour can be broken. As a result, a life of struggle can be transformed into an enabling environment.